is no doubt that Bhagat Singh adored his uncle Ajit Singh and even corresponded with him in exile and asked after him. Yet, remarkably, the influence on Bhagat Singh's political development of his family, who were themselves influenced by provincial developments in Punjab, has not been as well made out as it should have been. Common folklore in Punjab, however, makes no such mistake. This is as true on the Pakistan side as it is on the Indian side of Punjab.

So, the year 1907 set the stage for what was to follow over the following decades, with the emergence of a clear conflict with the government, and it was indeed this conflict within which the history of the Ghadar Party can be mapped as well. Bhagat Singh's own political trajectory needs to be understood against this backdrop. It is the historic failure to do so that has led to the wholesale pre-eminence being given to Gandhi's swadeshi/swaraj philosophy as the force for Independence, even though this had ended by 1911, whereas Bhagat Singh came into his own several years after that.

Sadly, little seems to have been learnt from this past. Modern-day India's Modi government appears to be quite oblivious of Punjab's tortuous history. Why else would it have so blithely passed on 5 June 2020 three ordinances on agricultural marketing which set out to structurally alter its basis? [9] The Indian economy was already in the grips of the maelstrom of the COVID-19 pandemic. As panic set in over the economy's catastrophic disintegration, the government, under cover of an unprecedented public health crisis and over the heads of state governments, forced through a series of highly controversial agricultural reforms, not unlike a hundred years ago, without consultation and without warning. Within three months on 14 September 2020, the three ordinances were before Parliament as legislative bills. Following a cursory discussion, they had the full imprimatur of the law by the end of the month, receiving the presidential assent on 27 September 2020, while leaving the public at large mystified about the government's purpose and vision for national agricultural policy. As with a hundred years ago, the government's intention was to 'modernize' farming practice by making it more competitive. As then, this is not how the farmers of Punjab understood it.